

What else to watch: *A Place in the Sun* (1951) ■ *The Wild One* (1953) ■ *Rebel Without a Cause* (1955, p.131) ■ *The Rose Tattoo* (1955) ■ *Baby Doll* (1956)

delusional madness of its central character. However, the movie was also criticized for its staginess, and it is true that Kazan refuses to open up the drama beyond the four peeling walls of Stella and Stanley's poky, run-down love nest. But it is the movie's claustrophobic atmosphere that becomes the source of its electricity—the actors prowl and pace the set like caged animals, straying into each other's territories and overstepping their marks.

This is especially true of Brando. A student of the "Method" approach to creating a character, he dedicated himself to unearthing

the inner life of the brutish Stanley, and the results are truly volcanic. The performance made Brando into a star, but even he could not outshine Vivien Leigh's flickering, iridescent portrait of a woman haunted by her own desires. "Whoever you are," she says at the end of the movie, her Southern-belle accent fluttering delicately around the sad truth at the heart of her self, "I have always relied on the kindness of strangers." ■

Stella's husband Stanley

has a brutish attraction for Blanche, but his attentions quickly turn to abuse.



Elia Kazan
Director

Turkish-born US director Elia Kazan was one of the most famous practitioners of the "Method" technique developed by Lee Strasberg, which encouraged actors to draw on their personal experiences and to "become" the characters they played. In the 1930s, he joined New York's experimental Group Theatre and triumphed on Broadway, cofounding the Actors Studio in 1947. By the mid-1950s he was a major player in Hollywood.

In 1952, Kazan testified before the House Un-American Activities Committee. Having been a member of the American Communist Party, he informed on eight former colleagues who had been communists. He resumed his career but his focus changed from controversial movies to historical allegories, such as an adaptation of John Steinbeck's *East of Eden*.

Key movies

1951 *A Streetcar Named Desire*
1954 *On the Waterfront*
1955 *East of Eden*
1961 *Splendor in the Grass*